Party-Congress partnership, the Gen Z moment suggested the two parties are building a common platform around issues that directly question the BJP's governance. Ideology need not be confronted directly—it is taking care of itself.

It was an unadulterated espousal of Hindutva that swept Yogi Adityanath to power in 2017—winning the BJP an imperious 312 out of the state's 402 seats. Five years later, its seat tally fell to 255, but credit that to the vagaries of the first-past-the-post system: its vote share had actually increased from 39.67 per cent to 41.67 per cent. Now, however, the alleged theft at Ayodhya means the saffron fuel that had powered Yogi now comes with a blend of scepticism.



Takeaways

- **SP-Congress ride on youth anger for 2027**
- **The plan is to focus on Yogi govt's performance: jobs, education, infra**
- **Ayodhya row allows it to let BJP handle ideology**

PERFORMANCE AUDIT

That leaves the Opposition free to address pure performance. In recent weeks, a clutch of issues has helped it mount a broad-spectrum attack. Some specific to UP, like at least five incidents in this monsoon where the state's spanking new highways have caved in, including sections on the flagship Lucknow-Kanpur and Ganga Expressways. The ethanol blending controversy has also received generous space in critiques. But it's education and student angst that could be causing the BJP its deepest worries.

The Gen Z protests had attracted a massive influx from Delhi's metropolitan shadow zone—a wide swathe of rural and Tier-2/3 towns around it. UP, where disrupted exams have become recurrent flashpoints, was very much part of it. The state also saw direct aftershocks from Jantar Mantar: hundreds of students, Hindu as well as Muslim, launched an intensive, multi-day sit-in protest at the gates of the Mohammad Ali Jauhar University in Rampur along with alumni and Opposition leaders in late July, after the government ordered 38 of its 40 buildings demolished. An interim court stay has only deferred confrontation.

UP also witnessed a copycat Gen Alpha protest: 1,500-plus students of a government-aided school in Fatehpur district agitated for better amenities. This time, the government saw wisdom in relenting. But UP is not spared the education/jobs hex: it lends over a fourth of the numbers in the NITI Aayog's estimate of a hundred thousand state schools being shut down in the past decade; central data also puts over 35 per cent of UP's youth in a different NEET: Not in Education, Employment, or Training.

But does the Opposition have enough internal coherence? The SP's 37 Lok Sabha seats in 2024 translate to 184 assembly seats, as against the BJP's 33/162. But this averaged-out extrapolation masks the fact that the SP was six points behind the BJP in vote share.

Also, the jury is still out on how well the SP-Congress partnership works on the ground—one reading is that Rahul's presence allowed the transfer of Dalit votes to the SP, in the context of the BSP's collapse. Whether the duo repeat the blunder of keeping Chandrashekhar Azad's Bhim Army aloof will also be a factor, with Dalits still searching for an anchor. But the sense is gaining ground that UP's default saffron tilt may have been corrected. ■

▶ MADHYA PRADESH

Datia, a Debacle Decoded

The BJP's bypoll loss owes to ambitions in conflict—the CM's play against veteran Mishra setting off revolt

By **Rahul Noronha**

DATIA IS HOME TO A PEETH FOR SHAKTI, associated with power. Not surprisingly, politicians land up here often. But this monsoon, 'Mai' showered her blessings on a homegrown one: Ghanshyam Singh, former royalty. The Congressman defeated the BJP's Ashutosh Tiwari by 6,016 votes in a byelection to the Datia assembly seat. The result, out on August 3, was subsumed within a larger story where the BJP saw a famous defeat in Bihar's Bankipur. But there was a local factor here—Narottam Mishra, ex-home minister and No. 2 under ex-CM Shivraj Singh Chouhan.

It was Mishra's dramatic prequel that single-handedly brought colour to the contest, and crafted its outcome. After an unbroken 15-year run, he had lost Datia to old Congress foe Rajendra Bharti in 2023. But a bypoll was forced after Bharti was convicted in a criminal





MESSY AFFAIR BJP leader Narottam Mishra (left) and CM Mohan Yadav